bring some of the ladies of the harem while Akbar and his retinue continued through snow, rain, and hail, often obliged to dismount from their horses and cross the passes on foot. Abu'l Fazl noted the dense forests covering the mountains and bridges over sparkling streams but by the time they reached the Pir Panjal Pass, the snow had become a silent, brooding presence for the inhabitants of Hindustan who had never seen such an expanse of aching white. 'Shall I describe the severity of the cold?' mused Abu'l Fazl. 'Or shall I tell of the depth of the snow, and of the bewilderment of the natives of India? Or shall I describe the heights and hollows of this stage?' As the party walked through falling snow, their breath coming in icy exhalations, their thoughts filled with dread prompted by stories of malevolent spells and djinns whispering through the passes. The locals, they found, used snow shoes, woven out of ropes of rice-straw, to walk over the powdery snow but Akbar disapproved of these so the men carried on as best they could.

Finally, the Mughal party made their way across the mountains and once beyond Hurapur came out onto a plateau. Here there were waterfalls, flowers, crisp and fragrant air, but unexpectedly, 'a cloud settled on the face of joy (Akbar)'. Salim had arrived at Hurapur without the ladies of the harem because he had deemed the conditions too dangerous for them to travel. Akbar flew into a sudden, explosive rage. A furious Padshah forbade Salim from presenting himself and raged at Abdur Rahim, who had accompanied the prince. 'If the prince, owing to his evil propensities, behaved in this way, why did you allow him to exhibit such audacity?' To the horror and great worry of his courtiers, Akbar then mounted his horse in the pouring rain and turned around with a small escort, proposing to bring back the harem himself. A thoroughly discomfited Abu'l Fazl admitted that 'I was nearly losing my senses and the dress of society was falling from my shoulders.' Terrified for the safety of the Padshah, Abu'l Fazl struggled to understand the reason for his unexpected rage. 'The whole confusion was caused by thinking why at such a time should the Shahinshah of the Universe become so angry? And why did he take upon himself this task which could be accomplished by a minor servant?' Salim, unsurprisingly, shut himself up in his tent, utterly mortified, refusing any food and drink. Akbar was eventually persuaded to return and Abdur Rahim was sent back to tend to the harem.